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Inspiring Excellence

HRM620 TERM PAPER

An Analysis of Inclusive HR Practices and Technological Adaptation at Microsign

Submitted by
Group 4

HRM620 Section: 2

Submission Date: 3rd May 2026

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1. Introduction

Microsign Products is one of the finest examples of inclusive employment especially at a time when there will be greater pressure on businesses to prove that they not only perform well financially but also have a positive impact on society. Microsign Products - Founded in 1979 by Nisheeth P. Mehta at Bhavnagar (Gujarat) and is a proprietary firm involved with making electrical electronics & auto components. The company gradually diversified into parts related to aerospace, shipbuilding and power plants serving clients such as BHEL, ISRO, ABB, Siemens, Larsen & Toubro and Bharat Dynamics Ltd. Microsign has achieved very high standards of quality with extremely low rejection rates and strong productivity; it has acquired ISO 9001(qms) certificate in addition to several certifications from national and international bodies including QS 9000.

A good company has a vision for their future in becoming a “tech savvy, socially responsible, world-class.” Based on principles of service above self, its mission dwells upon innovation, customer satisfaction, best place to work for employees and value in society. One of the milestones in the journey of Microsign happened in 1987 when his niece, who faced many challenges due to a disability, achieved success and that inspired CEO Nisheeth Mehta to hire differently abled workers. It began as a rather small initiative but made large strides, so that by 2017 nearly 60 per cent of the workforce was physically challenged, orthopedically handicapped, deaf-mute or mentally challenged. The organisation has therefore created a novel seven-pronged HR model that is founded on equality, recognising ability and creating an enabling environment as opposed to charity to support this heterogeneous workforce.

In 2017, Microsign had an important turning point despite its extraordinary social achievements and business success. Faced with greater competition from especially Chinese manufacturers, and driven by a need for higher quality output, Mehta decided to modernise the production process by bringing in more sophisticated machines manufactured in Germany. Although a much-needed technological upgrade for the long-term survival of the company, it also had big implications: would this new infrastructure interfere with well-ingrained HR practices and the one-of-a-kind “family-like” workplace culture that Hade was carefully nurtured over almost four decades.

This report examines the case by defining a problem, examining the solutions implemented in the company and offering alternative methods to execute an effective transition. It will provide valuable insights into how companies can realise meaningful technological advancement along with humane and inclusive human resource management.

2. Organizational & Industry Context

Microsign Products is a proprietary manufacturing firm founded by Nisheeth P. Mehta in 1979, headquartered in Bhavnagar, Gujarat, India. The company primarily manufactures electrical, electronic, and automobile components, with its product portfolio later expanding to include parts for the aerospace, shipbuilding, and power plant sectors. Over its three-decade history, Microsign evolved from a small component producer into a lean enterprise recognized for high productivity, minimal rejection rates, and strong capacity utilization. By 2017, the firm had established itself as a supplier to prestigious clients including BHEL, ISRO, ABB, Siemens, Larsen & Toubro, and Pawan Hans, while also meeting rigorous quality certifications such as ISO 9002, QS 9000, and defence standards JSS 54807 and JSS 54801.

2 The firm's organizational culture is deeply value-driven, anchored in principles of innovation, integrity, humanity, and selflessness. Microsign operates on a mission to "think differently, produce innovative ideas and quality products," and to identify the enterprise with the broader society. This philosophy translated directly into its most defining HR decision: the deliberate and large-scale recruitment of differently abled workers. Beginning in 1987, the firm actively hired physically, orthopedically, and hearing-impaired individuals, eventually building a workforce where approximately 60% of employees were differently abled, a figure virtually unparalleled in the Indian manufacturing sector.

From an industry perspective, Microsign operates in a highly competitive manufacturing environment that, between 2010 and 2017, experienced rapid technological advancement and intensifying global competition, particularly from Chinese manufacturers. The broader Indian manufacturing sector during this period faced pressure to modernize production processes in order to maintain cost efficiency and product quality. For companies employing a specialized workforce

like Microsign, this technological shift posed unique HR challenges, as adoption of advanced machinery requires re-skilling and can disrupt established, human-centered workflows.

In 2017, Mehta identified the need to adopt advanced German machinery to strengthen Microsign's competitive positioning and meet growing demands for higher quality products. This decision marked a pivotal moment, as it placed the organization at the intersection of technological modernization and the preservation of its inclusive, people-first HR culture, the very foundation of its identity and success over nearly four decades.

3. Problem Statement (Critical Issue Identification)

The key question in the Microsign case is in how an organization, which is based on a differently abled workforce, can survive in a growing competitive business environment and rapidly evolving technology. Nisheeth Mehta did not just find this challenge over the years, he built a working system of solutions that helped to keep the company not only profitable, but also socially relevant. These solutions can not be found on paper; they are firmly incorporated in the 7-pronged HR plan of the firm.

4. Solution(s) highlighted in the Case Study to Solve the Problem

The most basic solution Mehta presented was altering the discourse of disability as such. Microsign placed physically challenged workers not as a charity case or object of pity, but as a differently abled worker whose capabilities are different. This change in corporate mind was not simply superficial- it directly influenced recruitment, training, and day to day management. Deaf workers were subjected to work in noisy workplaces where their sensory difference actually worked in their favour. Employees who were cognitively different were placed on very repetitive jobs where consistency was the most important factor. In simple terms, the firm did not impose the ability to situation but instead made everyone conform to the same work structure.

The other valuable solution was to construct HR practices that were inclusive and performance-oriented. Microsign developed recruitment, training, career development and retention programs

that are uniquely designed specifically to meet the needs of differently abled employees without making them feel like they are singled out or viewed as inferior. Training was commonly the responsibility of supervisors who, themselves, were physically challenged, which of course further promoted the notion that career development was actually available. The first specially enabled employee Tukesh Bhatt, has retired after 30 years with the company - the clearest testament to how effective retention can be when inclusion is real and not just performative.

Mehta did not think of dumping his workforce model when the challenge of technological upgradation came in 2017. Rather, he reflected on how he would introduce new German machines without destroying the human-based culture that had taken decades to develop. He realized that high technology would require new skills but he still maintained a people-first approach where machines were considered as a tool and not a replacement. Seeking the TS: 16949 quality standard certification in addition to this upgrade demonstrated that he was serious about operational excellence and dignity to the workforce at the same time.

It turned out that what Microsign eventually learned is that there is no trade-off between inclusion and profitability. The firm increased its revenue by ₹15,000 to ₹80,000,000, reduced the rate of employee turnover, and gained national and international recognition. The solutions never were any grand gestures, they were simply consistent, practical and very human.

5. Recommend Alternative Solutions

Microsign's existing HR model is built on strong values, but it relies heavily on the founder's personal leadership. As the company moves toward adopting advanced technology, more structured and scalable solutions are needed to protect its inclusive culture. The following four alternatives are proposed to support this transition effectively.

5.1 Build Accessibility into the Machine Selection Process

Instead of buying new machines first and then figuring out how to make them work for differently abled employees, Microsign should include accessibility as a key selection criteria from

the beginning. A small evaluation team, including HR managers and floor supervisors, should check whether the German machines have features like visual alert systems for deaf workers and height-adjustable controls for those with physical limitations. This approach prevents costly modifications later and keeps inclusion at the core of business decisions, which aligns with Universal Design principles (Steinfeld & Maisel, 2012).

5.2 Create a Structured Peer Training Program for the Technology Shift

Microsign already has a strong culture of employees training each other, including differently abled supervisors teaching new workers. This strength should be formalized into an official peer training program for the technology transition. A selected group of experienced workers would first learn the new machines and then train their own teams. This method, known as the train-the-trainer model, helps employees feel more comfortable learning from someone they already trust, rather than an outside expert (Burke, 2023). It also keeps the family-like work environment intact during the change.

5.3 Roll Out Technology in Stages, Not All at Once

Introducing all new machinery at the same time is risky, especially for a workforce where 60% of employees are differently abled and may need more time to adjust. A better approach is to roll out the technology gradually, starting with a skills assessment to understand what each employee can do and what training they need (Kotter, 2012). Workers whose current jobs may change significantly can be moved to other suitable roles, such as quality checking or supervisory tasks, before the machines arrive. This protects job security and shows employees that the company still values them.

5.4 Document and Preserve the Inclusive HR Model Formally

Presently, much of Microsign's inclusive HR culture exists in practice but not on paper. If Mehta were to step down, there is a real risk that these practices could fade away. To prevent this, the company should write down its HR policies, training methods, and workplace accommodation

practices in a clear and organized format. Nonaka and Takeuchi (2007) argue that turning hands-on knowledge into written guidelines is essential for any organization to grow and survive long-term. Microsign's Centre of Excellence, opened in 2003, is the ideal place to store and share this institutional knowledge.

6. Conclusion

The case of Microsign Products offers a compelling and rare example of how a manufacturing firm can build enduring competitive strength not in spite of its inclusive values, but because of them. Over nearly four decades, Nisheeth Mehta demonstrated that hiring differently abled workers is not a philanthropic concession to social responsibility, it is, in fact, a sound and sustainable business strategy. The organisation's growth from a small proprietary firm to a supplier to institutions like ISRO and BHEL, paired with its exceptional retention rates and near-zero rejection figures, is a direct product of a workplace culture that treats every employee as a capable contributor. Microsign's journey challenges the widely held assumption that operational excellence and inclusive employment are competing goals. At Microsign, they are the same goal.

Nevertheless, the 2017 decision to introduce advanced German machinery marked a genuine inflection point for the company. The critical issue was never simply about machines or technological upgradation, it was about whether a deeply human-centred organisation could evolve without losing the very culture that made it exceptional. The solutions outlined in the case study, from reframing disability as differential ability to embedding inclusion into every layer of HR practice, reflect a leadership philosophy that prioritises dignity alongside productivity. Yet as the analysis in this report highlights, these solutions remain heavily reliant on the founder's personal vision and informal institutional knowledge. Without formalisation, without structured transition planning, and without proactive accessibility considerations built into future decisions, there is a real risk that what Mehta built over four decades could gradually erode as the organisation scales and leadership eventually changes hands.

The four alternative solutions proposed in this report, embedding accessibility into machine procurement, formalising peer-based training, phasing the technology rollout, and codifying the HR model, are not departures from Microsign's founding principles. They are logical extensions of them. Each recommendation seeks to institutionalise what has so far been held together by trust, personal commitment, and the quiet leadership of one individual. For organisations across the Indian manufacturing sector, and indeed globally, Microsign's model carries a lesson that is both practical and profound: inclusion, when pursued with sincerity and embedded in real policy, is not a burden on performance. It is a driver of it. The task ahead for Microsign is to ensure that this lesson outlasts its founder, takes root in its systems, and continues to guide the organisation as it navigates an increasingly competitive and technology-driven future.

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